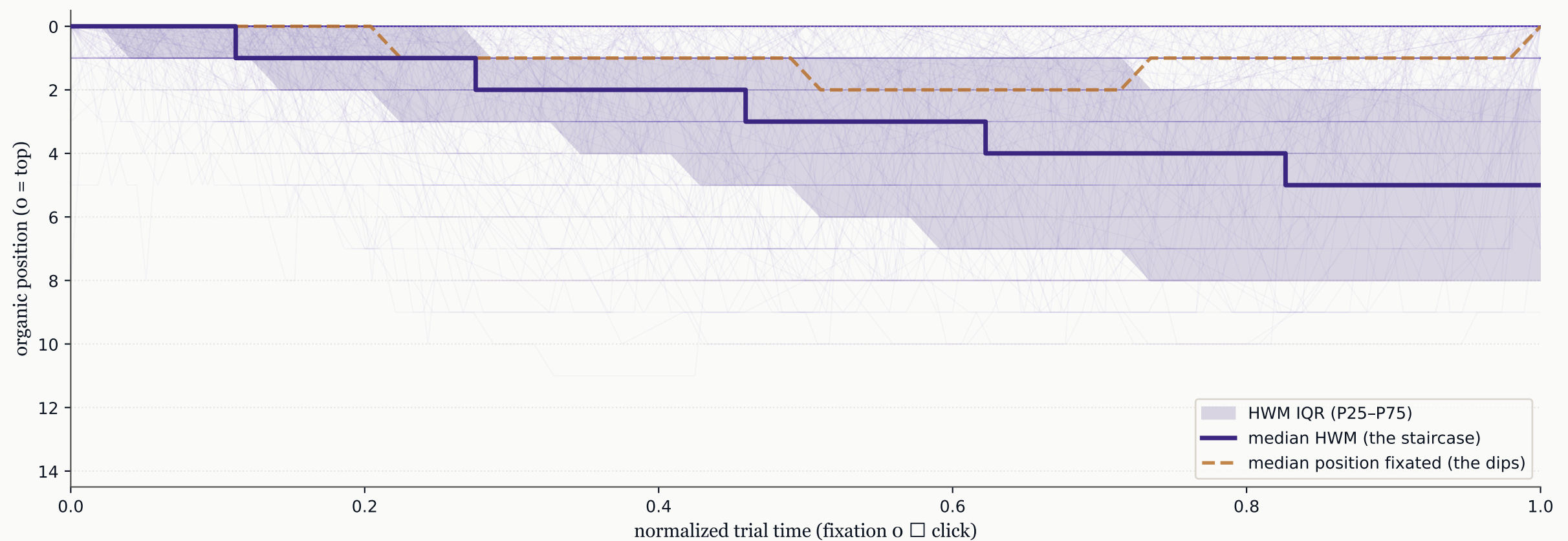


A. The staircase pattern is the population-level scan shape — [bbox-organic] · 2,681 trials · 63% of trials had ≥ 1 regress-scan-regress cycle



Definition: an "epoch" is a contiguous forward push of the high-water-mark (HWM = deepest rank reached).

A new epoch begins when the user, after regressing below HWM, advances HWM beyond its prior max — i.e., resumes scanning into territory not yet visited.

n_epochs = 1 □ pure forward (any regressions did not later push the HWM further). n_epochs = 2 □ one regress-scan-regress cycle. n_epochs ≥ 3 □ multiple cycles.

B. Small multiples by epoch count — one representative trial per stratum, regression fixations highlighted in orange · dotted line = HWM

n_epochs = 1
995 trials (37.1%)

n_epochs = 2
687 trials (25.6%)

n_epochs = 3
465 trials (17.3%)

n_epochs = 4
287 trials (10.7%)

n_epochs = 5+
247 trials (9.2%)

